

Grammar

Present simple, present continuous, stative verbs

Present simple

Form

statement

I/you/we/they **play** ...He/she/it **plays** ...

negative

I/you/we/they **do not (don't) play** ...He/she/it **does not (doesn't) play** ...

question

Do I/you/we/they **play** ...?**Does** he/she/it **play** ...?

Use

Present habits

Example

Marsha **goes** to dance lessons every Saturday.

Permanent situations

Does Dan **work** at the cinema?

States

I **like** the new James Bond film.

General truths

You **play** chess with 32 pieces.

Helpful hints

The present simple is often used with the following words and phrases:

adverbs

- always • usually • often
- sometimes • rarely • never

phrases

- every Monday/week/etc
- each Monday/week/etc
- once/twice a week/month/etc
- three times a week/month/etc

Remember that these adverbs usually go before the verb, but **after** the verb *be*.

- I **often** play football with my friends.
- I am **often** late for my piano lessons.

Watch out!

The verbs *be* and *have* have irregular present forms. See page 182.

Present continuous

Form

statement

I **am ('m) playing** ...He/she/it **is ('s) playing** ...You/we/they **are ('re) playing** ...

negative

I **am not ('m not) playing** ...He/she/it **is not (isn't / 's not) playing** ...You/we/they **are not (aren't / 're not) playing** ...

question

Am I **playing** ...?**Is** he/she/it **playing** ...?**Are** you/we/they **playing** ...?

Use

Actions happening now

Example

Jan **is watching** a DVD upstairs.

Temporary situations

She **is working** at the museum until the end of the month.Annoying habits
(usually with *always*)My brother **is always borrowing** my CDs without asking!

Helpful hints

The present continuous is often used with the following words and phrases:

- now • right now • at the moment
- today • this week/month/etc

Stative verbs

Form

Stative verbs do not usually describe actions. They describe states (feelings, thoughts, etc). They are not normally used in continuous tenses.

✓ I **like** reading books in my free time.✗ I ~~**am liking**~~ reading books in my free time.

Some common stative verbs:

appear

include

see

be

know

seem

believe

like

taste

belong to

love

think

hate

need

understand

have

prefer

want

Watch out!

Some of these verbs (such as *be*, *have* and *think*) are used in continuous tenses when they describe actions.

✓ What **do** you **think** about his new song?✓ I'm **thinking** about last night's match.